

MASCULINITIES AT WORK EVERYWHERE: A CASE STUDY OF GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE IN TANZANIA.

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1.0 Introduction

One day when travelling in a car, we passed by a group of women who were completely black-covered in their dressing. These women, particularly their dressing code, became a point of interest for some of us who were in the car. Why would such women be dressed that way in such a hot time of the day? And if one wanted to recognize any of them, how would he/she do it? Surely, these questions were provocative. Interestingly, one of the passengers had read a piece of more or less the same experience in a newspaper, which I shall, in big part, share in this article. This is a story titled "How the Talmud teaches modesty" by Dov Linzer, and Orthodox rabbi, Dean of the Yeshivat Chovevei Torah Rabbinical School in the Riverdale section of the Bronx. This is a story that will guide the reflection provided in this article.

An innocent, modestly dressed 8-year-old girl, Naama Margolese, living in Beit Shemesh, was spat on and vilified by religious extremists – all men – who believed that she did not dress modestly enough while walking past them to the religious school she attends. ... Woe to the girl or woman who refuses to move to the back of the bus.

This is part of a larger battle being waged in Israeli between the ultra-Orthodox and the rest of Israeli society over women's place in society, over their very right to have visible presence and to participate in the public sphere.

This is not a surprising kind of discussion in our everyday thinking and practice. Now and then, one hears women being asked not to put on mini skirts; it is common to hear that a certain woman sits "badly", or she walks like men. And when a question is posed why she should not put on a mini skirt or why she should not sit that way or why she should not walk like men, the response is stereotypic: when she is dressed or sits or walks like that, she tempts people. So, the solution is to sanction her in her dressing, sitting, and walking. Such reasoning sounds a remnant of the Adam and Eve myth whereby the latter is the temptress to the former!

But what is behind such attitude of men towards women? The story in the article alludes to this same question:

What is behind these deeply disturbing events? We are all told that they arise from a religious concern about modesty, that women must be covered and sequestered so that men do not have improper sexual thoughts. It seems, then, that a religious tenet that begins with men's sexual thoughts ends with men controlling women's bodies.

In this article, however, I would like to argue that the issue behind such negative attitude of men

over women goes beyond religious assumptions to issues of masculinities. The negative attitudes are simply an expression of men's masculinity traits to control sexuality of women. While in the private realm, it is contested by women leading to domestic violence, in the public it creates fear and submission of women to criminal acts of violence, such as rape. In fact, through this very newspaper story, I shall point out that we actually attribute masculinist interpretations of reality on the religious texts.

The article develops in the following way. The next section presents the methodological underpinnings behind this article. Clarification of issues of patriarchy, masculinity, and gender follow the methodological underpinnings. In another section, there is presentation of domestic violence, followed by another section that describes issues of insecurity. Before the final section that presents a conclusion and some food for thought there is presentation of a brief reflection on the findings.

2.0 Methodological underpinnings

This article uses primary and secondary data. The primary data is based on the focus group discussions in a country qualitative rapid assessment that was collected for the World Gender Report of 2012 in Tanzania. The fieldwork was undertaken for a period of two months in four villages. The data that has been selected for use in this article is about domestic violence and insecurity. Some of this primary data is analyzed through content analysis, particularly when bringing out reasons and processes on the different issues of domestic violence and safety issues. However, when it came to rating, statistical analysis has been used to establish domestic violence and safety indices.

Let me try to be a little more detailed on the establishment of indices. The men's and women's perceptions of domestic violence and safety had shares at each step. These steps presented the frequency of occurrence of domestic violence and perceptions of the presence of safety in the communities: the more the occurrence of violence and the more the perception of lack of safety, the lower the step. Thus, at the fourth step, which is the highest, domestic violence and lack of safety are almost never; at the third step, domestic violence and lack of safety are occasional; at the second step, domestic violence and lack of safety are regular, and; the first step, which is the lowest, domestic violence and lack of safety are frequent. These steps were considered for now and ten years ago.

Using summary statistics, it is possible to synthesize the distribution and change in these shares. The percentages of men and women who are thought to be in each step of domestic violence and lack of safety are taken for the past ten years and now. Then, there is presentation of the "mean" position where the village members can be found, or the "mean step". This mean step is calculated by multiplying each step by its respective share (percentage) and then adding the results together. Similarly, the "mean step" for the men "ten years ago" is calculated. In order to establish

the domestic violence and safety indices, the difference in the “mean steps” of now and ten years back are taken. In order to see who perceives more domestic violence and/or insecurity than the other between men and women, the indices are compared: whoever has higher index between men and women perceives domestic violence and/or safety to be higher compared to the other.

Secondary data has been derived from a story in a newspaper about how the Talmud teaches modesty. Actually, it is a newspaper story that is built around the Talmud. Talmud is a Hebrew term meaning “study” or “learning”, commonly referring to a compilation of ancient teachings regarded as sacred and normative by Jews from the time it was compiled until modern times. It is still so regarded sacred and normative by traditional religious Jews. The Talmud is composed of a set of books consisting of the Mishna, which is a collection of originally oral laws supplementing scriptural laws and Gemara, which is a collection of commentaries on and elaborations of the Mishna.

The use of the story that speaks about modesty built around Talmudic reflection is more of a methodological and presentational skill to put across issues of masculinity with regard to sexuality, than the importance of Talmud on people’s existence in Tanzania. The Talmud is an expression of human religious thought. This is symbolic of traditions, which actually, have had much effect on people’s ways of living by providing different spiritual insights and guidance, with reference to existential and transcendental values. As religion, is one of the most important structures that shape people’s behavior, the reflections using the Talmud become useful representative of an important element in people referential system.

The whole newspaper story is presented in this article. A portion of it is brought at the beginning of this article, in the introduction; the biggest portion of it is presented in the section about reflections; some few lines of the story are found in the section about the conclusion and food for thought.

3.0 Understanding Patriarchy, Masculinity, and Gender

This section is an attempt to understand the concepts of patriarchy, masculinity, and gender. Etymologically, the concept of patriarchy derives from two Greek words, pater (father) and arche (rule). These two words combined together brings about the notion of the ‘rule of the father’, which is an expression of the thinking as well as the resulting practice of the male predominance.¹

The concept of patriarchy has received attention on the issue of social arrangements organised around men. According to Hunnicutt (2009:557) patriarchy means “social arrangements

¹ Closely linked to this concept of patriarchy are the notions of patrilinearity and patrilocality. While patrilinearity refers to societies where the derivation of inheritance (financial or otherwise) originates from the father's line, patrilocality defines a locus of control coming from the father's geographic/cultural community. Due to patriarchy, most societies are predominantly patrilineal and patrilocal.

that privilege males, where men as a group dominate women as a group, both structurally and ideologically – hierarchical arrangements that manifest in varieties across history and space” at the macro level with bureaucracies, government, law, market and religion, and at the micro level with interactions, families, organizations and patterned behaviours between intimates. However, this distinction between the macro and micro exists analytically only because the micro and macro patriarchal systems exist symbiotically whereby interpersonal dynamics are nested within the macro level orders (Hunnicut 2009: 557-8).

The concept has also received attention in the different dimensions in which the ‘rule of the father’ is expressed. For example, Joseph (1996:14), with reference to the Arab societies, tries to define patriarchy as having to do with “the prioritising of the rights of males and elders (including elder women) and the justification of these rights within kinship values which are usually supported by religion”. This perspective stresses on the dimensions of age, kinship, and religion. Characteristically important is this issue of the elderly women being part of those who are prioritised in patriarchy. This is because, in the Arab conception, an elderly woman is one who has lived faithfully according to the rules and regulations of the ‘rule of men’, she has, in her lifetime, woven them thread by thread to become part and parcel of the fabric of her life, and she has proudly taught them to others. In addition to these dimensions, Hunnicut (2009: 558) advances more dimensions such as race, class, sexuality, historical location, and nationality. These dimensions in understanding patriarchy are very important because they “mediate gender statuses, assigning males and females varying amounts of social value, privilege, and power” (Idem) and become fields of hierarchy that generate and nurse systems of domination.

Much as patriarchy has to do with the male domination and female subordination, it should not be construed as universally homogeneous across time and space. It is from this notion of patriarchal heterogeneity that we can have multiple shapes and forms of patriarchy. For example, while oriental patriarchy encompassed polygamy and female enclosure, patriarchy in its European development has been based upon monogamy. There are still differences in familial and social patriarchies, as Eisenstein (1980: 44) points out: while familial patriarchy refers to the “hierarchical sexual organization for the reproduction of sex-gender² as it exists in the family”, social patriarchy refers to the “organization of sex-gender as it exists through the society understood as totality”. For Ursel (1984), however, there is another patriarchy, communal patriarchy, which corresponds to kin-based societies and has to do with the organisation of sex-gender as it exists within the kin-ship. Thus, at the most general level, the social organization of reproduction rests on the sexual division of

² The concept of sex-gender refers to “a set of arrangements by which the biological raw material of human sex and procreation is shaped by human, social intervention and satisfied in a conventional manner” (Rubin 1975: 165).

labour, which creates gender and provides a structural enforcement and re-enforcement of sexuality. From a political economic perspective, there could still be political patriarchy due to kinship that is central to the political system and economic patriarchy due to the privileging of males and elders in ownership and control over wealth and resources, including human resources (Joseph 1996: 15-16). Thus, patriarchy goes beyond the family, the kin-ship, to as far as all other institutions in society. Needless to say, patriarchy evokes images of hierarchies, dominance and power arrangements, all rotating men.

Gender is a matter of culture: it refers to the social classification into 'masculine' and 'feminine'. According to Lerner (1986, 238), it is the "costume, a mask, a straight jacket in which men and women dance their unequal dance". It is, therefore, a social construct that refers to relationships between men and women, with specifications of the socially and culturally prescribed roles that men and women are to follow.

The theorisations based on the linkages between sex and gender have led to the thinking that sex differences have an upper hand in the determination of the gender roles (Williams and Bennett, 1975). However, researches are giving contrary results. For example, Marini (1990) points out that there is no consistent evidence that the sexes differ in cognitive style, creativity, independence, susceptibility to influence, general self-esteem, emotionality, empathy, nurturance, sociability, or loquaciousness. This approach that unveils the wrong linkages between sex and gender is important because it challenges the "biological determinist assertions that gender inequalities in society were the natural and appropriate result of the biological differences between men and women" (Schech and Haggis 2000:86), and it puts at central stage culture whereby the specific cultural conceptions and symbolisations of woman are extra-ordinarily diverse and even mutually contradictory (Ortner 1981; Ortner and Whitehead 1981) to an extent that "the treatment of women, their status, and their contribution to society varied enormously from one culture to another" (Schech and Haggis 2000:86).

Gender as "socially learned behaviour and expectations that distinguish between masculinity and femininity" (Peterson and Runyan 1999:5) can be said to operate in at least three levels, which are interconnected (Marchand and Runyan 2000:137):

1) ideologically, especially in terms of gendered representations and valorisations of social processes and practices; 2) at the level of social relations; and 3) physically through the social construction of male and female bodies

It is gender at all the three levels that result into gender roles, which are what is expected of a man and woman as responsibilities by a society. The gender roles have worked mostly in favour of men, resulting into a number of gender-specific constraints faced by women. Gender gaps are widespread in access to and control of resources, in economic opportunities, in power, and political

voice; women are still exploited, discriminated, and subject to harassment and violence; the roles lead to women's lack of access to productive resources and low levels of human capital; they lead to possible inefficiencies in intra-household allocation and the interaction between economic factors and gender roles in productivity and well-being.

Linked to this concept of gender is the concept of masculinity. Masculinity is a part of what is known as gender identity, that is, the degree to which people see themselves as masculine or feminine, given what it means to be a man or woman in society (Burke, Stets and Pirog-Good 1988; Spence 1985). Masculinity, as well as femininity, is rooted in the social (one's gender) rather than the biological (one's sex) constructions. Members in a given society internalize what it means being male or female. For this matter, then, males will generally respond by defining themselves as masculine while females will generally define themselves as feminine. What is important is the fact that masculinity and femininity are social definitions. That is why it is possible for one to be female and see herself as masculine or male and see himself as feminine.

Masculinity involves all the meanings that are applied to a person on the basis of gender identification as man. According to Burke (1980), these meanings are a source of motivation for gender-related behavior. If a society has given meaning to a masculine identity as being more dominant, competitive and autonomous, for example, a person with a more masculine identity should act more masculine, that is, engage in behaviors whose meanings are more masculine, namely being more dominant, competitive, and autonomous (Ashmore, Del Boca, and Wohlers 1986). In actual fact, it is not the behaviors themselves that reveal masculinity, but the meanings implied by those behaviors. The self-meanings about the male gender are fruit of socialization from ongoing interaction with significant others such as parents, peers, and educators (Katz 1986).

How are these concepts of patriarchy, masculinity and gender related? Patriarchy, being the rule of the father, acts as a structure that informs gender relations that have man as the norm. It is from this norm that the gender identities are constructed, that is, being masculine or feminine, given the social meanings. Thus, what is defined as masculine has its opposite in the feminine. And the biggest expression of masculinity is the character of "strength", with its counterpart being "weakness", as a character for femininity.

4.0 Domestic violence: Contestation over Sexuality

In this section, I deal with the presentation of data about domestic violence in two ways. First, I establish the extent of domestic violence as perceived by communities ten years back and now. The perceptions lead to establishment of the domestic violence index. Secondly, I establish how domestic violence is a function of contestation over the sexuality privileges that men have got from the

masculinity constructions.

Data clearly indicates that both men and women agree that there is domestic violence in their communities, even though, men perceive more violence 10 years ago than it is currently and women, instead, perceive more domestic violence now than it was 10 years ago. The domestic violence index shows this in the table below.

	<i>% Now</i>	<i>% 10 yrs ago</i>	<i>Weighted Mean now</i>	<i>Weighted Mean 10 years ago</i>	<i>Domestic violence index (Difference in means)</i>
Men's perception of domestic violence, Tanzania					
Almost never	14	50	2.46	3.5	1.04
Occasionally	18	50			
Regularly	68	0			
Frequently	0	0			

(Source: Men and women, Nyamukazi, Ijuganyondo, Chibelela, Mbabala A FGD)

As for the women, the domestic violence index is as follows:

	<i>% Now</i>	<i>% 10 yrs ago</i>	<i>Weighted Mean now</i>	<i>Weighted Mean 10 years ago</i>	<i>Domestic violence index (Difference in means)</i>
Women's perception of domestic violence, Tanzania					
Almost never	36	17	3.2	2.58	0.62
Occasionally	48	27			
Regularly	16	23			
Frequently	0	23			

(Source: Men and women, Nyamukazi, Ijuganyondo, Chibelela, Mbabala A FGD)

This perceived violence, however, has to do with the contestation over sexuality privileges that men have got from the masculinity constructions. Basically, men have got a sex privilege of controlling women's. It is from this privilege that several practices have been constructed about men and women's sexuality.

The first practice is polygamy: "Here we marry many wives" (Man, FGD, Village 3, August 2012). This is a practice where a man marries many women.

A man can marry as many wives as he wants because he has enough cattle and land. Look, I wanted to marry the third wife; I had opened another household with heads of cattle; the second wife comes to me and says if I get married, she goes away. Fine, that is equality; it is not even clear who the man in the house is; she did not know that I can marry another wife and she thinks she can only control me because of equality. I married and she is there: where could she go? (Man, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

Actually, they [men] marry many women to get more children. When they see you giving birth to few, they marry another one (Young woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

Polygamy is contested by women:

... Our men marry many wives here. Why can't they marry a few, actually only one? They do not have much, but still they marry and marry. This should change (Young Woman, FGD,

Village 3, August 2011)

They [men] should actually marry less wives, only one actually. Look at 'P': he also has three wives: what can he provide? He can't even provide for himself (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

Jealousy has been used as a contestation method, together with quarreling:

Men here like to marry a lot; of course they marry us; but then, even if you were the one, you see your man going to sleep with another woman somewhere else for a number of days and you are simply there and you need him, what do you do? You become jealous and when he comes you simply have to quarrel with him (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

And men are aware about women's contestation of polygamy:

And sometimes when you come home from another house, your wife will look at you badly and if you asked for sex, she would simply give you a back (Man, FGD, Village 3, September 2011)

Another practice is that men move around with as many women as they desire. While in the previous expectation of men being polygamous, there is recognition of marriage, at least customarily, in this second expectation, men's hanging out with many women is considered as cheating. Sometimes cheating is assumed, and not necessarily that it has happened, but still it has effects of leading to quarrels, fights, denials (food, sex), and closing out people:

Our work [fishing] is terrible: you go in the lake the whole night and you face the wind; you do not get even a single fish. And your wife tells you that you cheated on her you had not gone fishing, you had gone to sleep with young girls. The next thing you do is to beat her up. (Man, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

I quarreled with my wife because she was told that I was moving out with another woman. There was a time I moved with her to the main road, just by coincidence. A word passed that she was my concubine and we had gone to have fun together in town. This was not true, but was misunderstood. We really fought over this for almost a year: sometimes I was not give food; if I came home late, I was not opened the door; or sometimes I would be denied of sex (Man, FGD, Village 2, August 2011)

Sometimes, cheating is real: men move around with many women:

Men run around with many women. This is a big problem and has caused lots of fight in the families. Why should I be married and there is someone else who is in the middle in a hidden place? But once you point out this to your man, then you begin problems in the house because you will be abused or beaten up in front of the children. (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011).

The contestation of cheating in this quote begins from seeing the practice as a problem, followed by a dialogue between the man and woman, ending up with abuses and battering as expressions of domestic violence.

Conversely, though, women are not supposed to engage in moving out with as many men as they would wish. This is with the case of prostitution. Actually, prostitution does not mean exchanging sex for money, but rather a woman moving out with men who are not husbands. Once a

woman is labeled as a prostitute, then, she has, actually, a right to be battered, with disastrous consequences to the family in general, and the children and man in particular:

Once you discover your wife a prostitute, what do you do? You remember Mr 'E': ... beating and beating and beating the wife. He was right, I think, because a prostitute is a dangerous wife. And you saw what happened: all the children ran away and now they have separated. Look at how stressed he is; he cannot manage even to cook for himself; he can't shower; he is finished (Man, FGD, Village 4, August 2011)

Of course, the case with prostitution shows the double standards in the treatment about sex affairs: while for men cheating is dealt with beginning from a discussion between a man and woman, even though it ends up with domestic violence, man abusing and beating the woman, with women cheating, there is no discussion and the man just beats the woman.

Jealousy and the related violence of fighting and use of abusive words are practices that stem from men's privilege over sexuality. Men are aware about it and talk about it this way, for example, while talking about polygamy:

But we [men] have to be honest again that sometimes we [men] are the ones who cause jealousy [when we marry many wives]: women become jealous of themselves and they begin fighting, abusing each other. (Man, FGD, Village 3, August 2012)

Thus, the men's privilege to practice polygamy is causative of jealousy. Women are aware about their being jealousy as a practice that leads to their negative relationship with their fellow women: "We have to be honest: nobody likes to see her man with another woman" (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2012). However, women are not simply victims, but contestors of polygamy:

... when our men come back home after being somewhere with another wife, we end up fighting, abusing each other. And actually, the more you harass your man for having another woman, he abandons you and gets another one. It is terrible, but that is how our men are (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2012)

Another practice has to do with the female genital alteration, which has popularly been known as female genital mutilation.

We women have suffered a lot. One of the things that has really made us suffer during our age was this practice of 'kukeketa' [cutting part of women genitalia]. It was common practice and with so many reasons, particularly for health and not being sexually aroused easily (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

... Even nowadays there are still children who are taken for it. It is very hidden, but it is done to children; it is difficult to know, but it is there. The 'ngariba' [the traditional women who perform the operation] are still there and we all know them. What do you think is their task? You will hear a child has gone to visit the aunties during the holidays, that is it: she has gone for an operation (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

The assumption behind such practice is that it is only men who are supposed to enjoy sex. Removing the part of the genitalia of the woman, particularly the sensitive parts should lead her to less pleasure in sex, and hence less will to sex. This is a practice that has had more overt contestation to an extent that its practice now is hidden.

Women have learnt how to fight back this sexuality privilege of men by using the same

privilege: they deny men sex as part of the punishment process.

Why should I sleep with a man who is violent on me? I deny him sex. I know that I did not solve a lot because sometimes he forces me. Most of the times, however, I resisted (Woman, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

And for me if my husband comes from another wife, I do deny him sex for a full week, not less; I do not care, however much he complains; that is my way to teach him a lesson (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

Not only has it been a matter of denying sex, but separation all together for fear of even sexually transmitted diseases:

But again, even when I resisted he could go and have sex with other women outside. That is why I left because I did not want to contract HIV/AIDS (Woman, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

Denial of sex and sometimes separation has happened due to people experiencing and listening to testimonies, such as the following:

I am now HIV/AIDS positive; it is because of my man who when he went drinking he would also sleep with other women over there. I first got the sexually transmitted diseases (STIs), which disturbed me a lot, and after sometime I was falling sick every time only to find myself HIV/AIDS positive. I am too stressed, especially when I think that at some point not very far, I shall have to die, and him also, and leave my children as orphans (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

And men are quite aware of denial of sex as part of punishment for their sex privileges:

... we are nowadays getting punished also? They don't give us "goods" [sex], if we are not good. You just touch her and she abuses you or she says she is in her periods [menstruation]. But these menstruations which do not finish, what are they? (Man, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

One more practice that I would like to present here is about men controlling women's time:

But for me it is clear: when it is dark and my wife is not yet in, she sleeps wherever she has been (Man, FGD, Village 1, August 2011).

Can you really complain that Mr 'D' beats up his wife? What kind of wife is that one who comes in at any time, drunk, and does nothing during the day? That woman has lacked respect totally and that is why she is always beaten. Actually, I stopped going to reconcile them, it is too much (Man, FGD, Village 2, August 2011)

As a way to contest this practice, women use the same strategy on men, which actually seems to be effective:

You must be very careful, nowadays: you come late at home you find the door locked; you say you want to go out at night, you find the door locked. No entering, no getting out (Man, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

5.0 Rape: Submission to Male Violence

What is seen as domestic violence is actually masculinity expressed in terms of sexual violence that men, generally, inflict on women in the private realm. In the public realm, however, rape is the case.

Rape issues are expressed differently by women and men, as can be seen in the following quotes.

Young men seem to be at the driver's seat for rapes:

Currently young men are dangerous. The rape cases are so many. They rape even children, and not only women and girls. It is very dangerous walking at night here with all these drunk men who are looking for women to sleep with. There is a guy here. He raped a small girl in those classrooms there. The girl said that he gave her sweets and slept with her. Some other small girls say he has done it to them. So it is his habit for him and people fear talking about it openly here (Woman, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

And another testimony

It happened to me sometime back with my daughter who is handicapped at home. She was raped and I took the man to court. The man was imprisoned, but everybody blamed me over the action of taking him to court (Woman, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

In the eyes of men and women, safety seems to be more of an issue that affects women than men, as pointed out by several people in the communities:

... it is women who are mostly attacked by men for rape. Stealing can happen in anybody's home, regardless of whether it is a man's or woman's home (Woman, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

I do not think so; but women need to be more careful; moving at night can be dangerous for them. Actually, a young woman was almost raped in this street in the evening when she was going to fetch water (Man, FGD, Village 2, August 2011)

When you are a woman, do not risk to go long distances at night; you might end up in trouble because people can do bad things to you; they can steal from you or they can even abuse you or in some cases because it has happened, they can rape you (Woman, FGD, Village 4, August 2011)

You see, you always wonder: you or your daughter passes somewhere and you see these men saying funny words at you; so, if it was during the dark, wouldn't they go farther and rape or hurt you? We women need to be more careful, no doubt (Woman, FGD, Village 3, August 2011)

Such perceptions of lack of safety inflicted upon women has led to both women and men agreeing upon the presence of insecurity in Tanzania, but particularly the perception that there is more insecurity now than ten years ago. This is demonstrated in the following safety indices.

	<i>% Now</i>	<i>% 10 years ago</i>	<i>Weighted Mean now</i>	<i>Weighted Mean 10 years ago</i>	<i>Safety index (Difference in means)</i>
Men's perception of safety, Tanzania					
Very safe	38	5	3.86	2.5	1.81
Safe	34	5			
Neither nor safe	11	5			
Dangerous	11	59			
Very dangerous	5	27			

(Source: Men and women, Nyamukazi, Ijuganyondo, Chibelela, Mbabala A FGD)

And for women, the safety index is as follows:

	<i>% Now</i>	<i>% 10 years ago</i>	<i>Weighted Mean now</i>	<i>Weighted Mean 10 years ago</i>	<i>Safety index (Difference in means)</i>
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Women's perception of safety, Tanzania					
Very safe	0	2	2.54	1.74	0.8
Safe	39	7			
Neither nor safe	4	7			
Dangerous	30	52			
Very dangerous	26	11			

(Source: Men and women, Nyamukazi, Ijuganyondo, Chibelela, Mbabala A FGD)

But why is it that there is perception of more insecurity now than ten years ago? Two quotes from men are illustrative: drinking and marijuana smoking habits are characteristically attributes of young men that lead to violent and criminal behavior.

We have so many young men here. A good number of them drink and smoke marijuana. And life is not that easy for them. These are becoming more violent and violent. Actually, what they do is stealing; but again we have cases of rapes here: women are being raped. There is even a guy who has killed two people here; he threatened to kill another one. He is here (Man, FGD, Village 1, August 2011)

... you have to be careful when moving at night. These many young men who are jobless or ride these bodabodas, sometimes they take marijuana and you can encounter them and they hurt you (Man, FGD, Village 2, August 2011).

The basic point is that men are at the centre of the insecurity of the communities, which is an expression of their internalized gender identity of men as strong, an element shown through violence. Thus, while at one level domestic violence is an expression of masculinity to control women's sexuality in the domestic realm, at another level, rape is similarly an expression of masculinity to control women's sexuality in the public. But what does domestic violence have to do with our discussion about negative attitudes of men against women? This is discussion for the next section.

6.0 Reflection over the findings

The main argument that was to be developed in this article was that behind the negative attitudes of men against women are issues of masculinity, of which religious expressions are part. Continuing with our newspaper story, we can learn something with respect to how men hide in religious foundations in order to justify their constructed sexualized imaginations:

The ultra-orthodox men in Israel who are exerting control over women claim that they are honouring women. In effect they are saying: we do not treat women as sex objects as you in the western societies do. Our women are about more than their bodies, and that is why their bodies must be fully covered.

In fact, though, their actions objectify and hypersexualise women. Think about it: by saying that all women must hide their bodies, they are saying that every woman is an object who can stir a man's sexual thoughts. Thus every woman who passes their field of vision is sized up on the basis of how much of her body is covered. She is not seen as a complete person, only as a potential inducement to sin.

Of course, once you judge a female human being only through a man's sexualized imagination, you can turn even a modest 8-year old girl into a seductress and a prostitute.

What becomes serious is the fact that the responsibility of managing the constructed sexualized imaginations of men become a responsibility for women.

At heart, we are talking about a blame-the-victim mentality. It shifts the responsibility of managing a man's sexual urges from himself to every woman he may or may not encounter. It is a cousin to the mentality behind the claim, "she was asking for it".

So, the responsibility is now on the women. To protect men from their sexual thoughts, women must remove their femininity from their public presence, ridding themselves of even the smallest evidence of their own sexuality.

All of this is done in the name of the Torah and the Jewish Law.

With the woman's responsibility to manage the sexualized imaginations of men, then, there is inbuilt a mechanism whereby institutions become a fertile ground for breeding masculinity justifications, on the one hand, and integrating masculinity constructions in institutions, on the other hand.

It is important that masculinities are questioned everywhere.

This is not a problem unique to Judaism. But the Talmud, the basis for Jewish law, offers a perhaps surprising answer: it places the responsibility for controlling men's licentious thoughts about women squarely on the man. Put more plainly, the Talmud says: It's your problem, sir; not theirs.

In actual fact, using religious assumptions to justify masculinities is quite contrary to what is expected of these religious texts:

But it's actually a complete perversion. The Talmud, the source of the Jewish law, acknowledges that men can be sexually aroused by women, and is indeed concerned with sexual thoughts and activity outside of marriage.

But it does not tell women that men's sexual urges are their responsibility. Rather, both the Talmud and the later codes of Jewish law make that demand of men.

It is forbidden for a man to gaze sexually at a woman, whether beautiful or ugly, married or unmarried, says the Talmud. Later Talmud rabbis extended this ban even to "her smallest finger" and "her brightly colored clothing – even if they are drying on the wall".

To make these the woman's responsibility is to demand that the Jewish women cover their hands, and that they not dry their clothes in public. No one has ever said this. At least not yet.

And the sexual urge responsibility is, actually, to be taken by men themselves, and not someone else because it is the way they themselves look at sexuality that needs to be changed:

The Talmud tells the religious man, in effect: if you have a problem, you deal with it. It is the male gaze – the way men look at women – that need to be desexualized, not women in public. The power to make sure men don't see women as objects of sexual gratification is in men's – and only men's - control

Issues of sexuality go beyond the outside appearance of people; they encompass values that should promote the authentic worth of human beings and respect each other, beginning from the self:

Jewish tradition teaches men and women alike that they should be modest in their dress. But modesty is not defined by, or even primarily about, how much of one's body is covered. It is about recognizing that one need not be the center of attention. It is about embodying the prophet Micah's call for modesty: learning "to walk humbly with your God".

7.0 Conclusion and Food for Thought

Masculinity, expressed in terms of control over sexuality of women, is everywhere; it is expressed in the public realm, as well as in the private; it is expressed not only in the developing, but as well as the developed countries; it gets justifications from new, as well as old traditions. In a word, masculinity is everywhere at work. In some instances, masculinity is contested, as has been the case with the private realm where contestation has resulted in domestic violence; in some other instances, masculinity intimidates people, as has been with the case of the public realm where women even become submissive to violence, such as rape.

As food for thought, it is important that men are stimulated to search for values that should challenge their sexuality-privileged masculinity. The process for the search should begin from a simple course of learning from the everyday little encounters with what challenges men, as the newspaper story points out. "Eight-year-old Naama could teach her attackers a thing or two about modesty". For men, this might be the toughest thing to do, as Leo Tolstoy points out:

I know that most men, including those at ease with problems of the greatest complexity, can seldom accept even the simplest and most obvious truth if it would oblige them to admit the falsity of conclusions which they have delighted in explaining to colleagues, proudly taught to others, and which they have woven, thread by thread, into the fabric of their lives.

Not only should men get into a course of learning from the everyday little encounters, but there should be a deliberate effort from men to question and challenge structures that, in one way or the other, promote human inequalities. One of the structures to be questioned is the religious structure, however much discomforting it could be for men as it has always privileged men. The opening of our story is cynical about this:

Is it possible for a religious demand for modesty to be about anything other than men controlling women's bodies? From recent events in Israeli, it would certainly seem that it is not.

Similarly, the different structures that try to sanction women from their dress codes, the way they sit, the way they talk or walk, etc, are nothing else other than strategies to control women's sexualities

9.0 References

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